The Shape of Attention

This is placeholder text for the second essay. The accordion on the Essays page loads these words, and the Download PDF button hands over a PDF built from this same file.

Attention has a shape. It narrows to a point when we are absorbed and widens to a horizon when we are at rest. Most of modern life is an argument about which of those shapes you will hold, and for how long, and on whose terms.

The economics of a glance

A glance is cheap to give and expensive to recover. Whole industries are built on the difference. To guard your attention is not to withdraw from the world but to decide, deliberately, where its light will fall.

Depth as a decision

Depth is less a talent than a decision renewed each hour. We go deep by declining the next easy distraction, and then the one after that, until the quiet work in front of us becomes the most interesting thing in the room.

Swap this text for your own thoughts on focus, distraction, or anything else. The structure — a title, a couple of sections, a short close — travels well.